

Icons

Icons, from the Greek word *eikones*, are sacred images representing holy figures, usually Christian saints and biblical characters.

Byzantine icons appeared in painting, sculpture and mosaics, and ranged in size from miniature to monumental. Small icons were often used for private prayer, while large icons adorned churches, helping congregations to focus on worship.

In Byzantine theology, contemplation of icons enabled viewers to make contact with the figures represented, so that personal prayers could reach them directly. Symbolism, including objects, methods of representation and colour were important. For instance, gold represented the radiance of Heaven and blue symbolized life. Icons were intended more as religious objects than works of beauty, but this caused problems when viewers came to believe the sacred figures were actually present in the art. In c.726, the Eastern Church banned their use completely. Often called the 'First Iconoclasm', the ban lasted until 787, and the 'Second Iconoclasm' occurred between 814–842.



Icon of Our Lady of Kazan, Moscow (19th century reproduction)